

COVER STORY : PARIS OLYMPICS 2024

THE GOLD QUEST

By SUHANI SINGH

'Citius, Altius, Fortius—Communiter' says the updated Olympic motto which translates to faster, higher, stronger—together. Another Latin word can be considered here—'fortuna'. Luck, or as Satwiksairaj Rankireddy, one half of the Asian Games gold medal-winning badminton duo, says, "destiny", plays a pertinent role. For a fortnight, a nation will be hoping some of it showers on our athletes, some of whom are celebrities, like Neeraj Chopra and P.V. Sindhu, while others quietly go about representing the nation in little-known disciplines. Take Kolkata-born, Germany-trained Anush Agarwalla, the first Indian to compete in dressage, an equestrian event akin to a choreographed fancy footwork routine. The Olympics is also that time of the year when all nations indulge in their favourite pastime: the how-many-medals guessing game. India's medal tally "will all depend on shooting", says Manisha Malhotra, head of sports, excellence and scouting at JSW Sports, which backs Paris-bound athletes like Neeraj Chopra, wrestler Antim Panghal and runner Avinash Sable. "I do believe that if shooting clicks in the first two days, it's a whole different Olympics." With 21 of our 117-member contingent made up of shooters, India will be praying that assessment comes true. This issue, we are profiling 17 champions across 13 disciplines. Some are debutants while there are some making a commendable fourth appearance, like hockey players P.R. Sreejesh and Manpreet Singh. Ultimately, the Olympics is two weeks of guaranteed exhilarating action featuring the best athletes across the world. In a media interaction in April, Chopra said he hoped people would watch the Olympics with the same enthusiasm as they do the IPL. "That's how our sporting culture will change," he said. And maybe that's how a child will be inspired to pick up the javelin or the hockey stick and go on to win an Olympic medal. ■